

“ I PLEDGE MYSELF TO A NEW DEAL FOR THE AMERICAN PEOPLE. ”

Franklin D. Roosevelt, at his nomination acceptance speech, 1932



Young women in Florida having their backs decorated with the Blue Eagle of the National Recovery Administration, a major plank of Roosevelt's New Deal.

Americans accepted Roosevelt's assurance that the banks were now safe and came forward to deposit their savings—a confidence trick that worked.

Through the frenetic first 100 days of his administration, Roosevelt pushed through a raft of legislation to fulfil his promise of a “**New Deal**.” The measures were neither entirely coherent nor uniformly successful. The wages of federal employees were cut. Farmers were paid to leave land fallow and slaughter animals, to raise farm prices. The **National Recovery Administration** pressured businesses to raise wages and prices, to increase profitability and consumer demand. The Tennessee Valley Authority brought electricity and modernization to one of the most economically backward regions in the US. Most popular were

direct work creation programs such as those organized by the **Civil Works Administration**. These ranged from important construction projects to “boondoggles”—futile jobs to keep men employed.

Above all, Roosevelt's personal leadership had a dramatic effect on American morale. His warm-hearted radio broadcasts, known as “**fireside chats**,” convinced many Americans that they truly had a friend in the White House.

The British, meanwhile, were desperate to restore international free trade, and to end the slide toward protectionism and devalued currencies. When a **World Economic Conference** assembled in London, however, Roosevelt insisted on the right of the US to manipulate its own exchange rate and to deploy tariffs in its national interest.

4.4 YEARS THE AVERAGE LIFE EXPECTANCY OF A MALE CHILD BORN IN UKRAINE IN 1933

The conference failed and, in the absence of international cooperation, all the countries that attended continued to pursue aggressive nationalist policies, blocking the overall recovery of the world economy.

While capitalist countries struggled with the Depression, the communist **Soviet Union** seemed immune to such problems. Hidden from the outside world, its people suffered a different catastrophe. While Soviet propaganda celebrated rising output, in 1932–33 **famine gripped the Ukraine** and other grain-producing areas, killing millions of the rural population. It mainly came about as the result of the collectivization of agriculture (see 1930). But the scale of the disaster was vastly increased by Stalin's insistence

on forcibly extracting grain from starving rural areas to feed cities.

At a time of widespread distress and upheaval, it was perhaps ironic that the **Chicago World's Fair**, opening in May, celebrated a “Century of Progress.” The American public loved the fair's celebration of the onward march of technology, but not everything was devoted to “progress.” The burlesque dancer Sally Rand was a major hit with her “fan dance,” so too was the arrival of 24 Italian flying boats commanded by marshal of the Italian Air Force Italo Balbo, and a visit from the German airship *Graf Zeppelin*.

The Chicago Fair's emphasis on achievements in the air was timely, for this was the year in which the technology of **air travel** reached a critical turning point. The introduction of the all-metal, streamlined, monoplane **Boeing 247** airliner, which was capable of cruising at over 150 mph (241 kph), transformed journey times. The 247 could carry 10 passengers coast-to-coast across the US in just 20 hours. The Douglas Aircraft Company responded with the **DC-1** and **DC-2**, which shaved a further two hours off a transcontinental scheduled flight. Air travel was still expensive though and remained a form of transport used only by the well off.



World's Fair programme
The 1933 Chicago World's Fair, staged on the shore of Lake Michigan, took the theme of science, technology, and industry.

A **strange incident** occurred in January 1933. The game of **cricket**, the playing of which was one of the ritual bonds holding together the British Commonwealth, **led to a diplomatic crisis**. The English team touring **Australia** adopted intimidating “**bodyline**” tactics, its fast bowler Harold Larwood aiming deliveries at the Australian batsmen's chests and heads. After two Australian players were injured at Adelaide, Australian protests went to government level. Intervention by the **British foreign office**, eager to maintain good relations with an assertive Commonwealth state, ensured that the unapologetic Larwood never played Australia again.

FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT (1882–1945)

Franklin Delano Roosevelt entered politics as a Democrat before World War I. As governor of New York from 1928 he led efforts to provide relief for the unemployed. Elected president four times, from his first presidential campaign in 1932 he transformed American politics by attracting the votes of labor unions, ethnic minorities, and African-Americans. His New Deal policies won him enduring popularity, reinforced by his leadership during World War II.

